



Jews living in Spain who converted to Christianity, such as Pablo de Heredia whose *Epistle of Secrets* is often seen as the first significant work of Christian Kabbalah. When, in 1492, non-converted Jews were expelled from Spain, Kabbalah spread across Europe.

The tree of life

Renaissance Christian Kabbalists included Pico della Mirandola (see below); Johann Reuchlin, who wrote *On the Art of Kabbalah*; Cornelius Agrippa, whose *De Occulta Philosophia* linked Kabbalah and magic; and Paulus Ricius, translator of Joseph Gikatilla's *Gates of Light* (see left), said to contain the first non-Jewish image of the tree of life. A symbol drawn from Jewish Kabbalah, the tree of life links with Hermetic ideas of unity between humanity, divinity, and the universe, and with the Hebrew Tetragrammaton—an ordering of four letters used to express God's name.

“... the magician is the minister of nature and not merely its artful imitator.”

PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA, *ORATION ON THE DIGNITY OF MAN*, 1486

GIOVANNI PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA (1463–1494)

Father of Christian Kabbalah

Mirandola was among the first to introduce Kabbalah into Christian and Western culture. He promoted an interest in ritual magic within Christianity, and his writing drew together strands including Jewish mysticism, Platonism, humanism, and Hermeticism. Mirandola distinguished beneficent, natural magic—linked to God's divine workings—and natural philosophy from harmful magic. In 1486, he planned to defend a collection of his ideas, known as *900 Conclusions*, before a gathering of scholars from all over Europe, but the assembly was forbidden and his theses were condemned by the papacy.

